Chapter 5 – The Empire of Chandragupta Maurya

The self-appointed savior of India was Chandragupta Maurya, a man whose birth is shrouded in mystery thanks to conflicting historical accounts. Indian historians do agree that at some point in Maurya's youth, he was adopted as a student by the great political philosopher, Vishnugupta, also known as Chanakya. His teachings in politics and warfare helped him take control of the subcontinent and make it possible for his dynastic family to transform India from a land of patchwork political factions into a centralized empire.

Chandragupta Maurya didn't immediately set his sights on the establishment of an empire. As a young man during the time of Alexander's invasion, Maurya was a teacher in Takshasila (Taxila). It was only at the behest of his guru and father figure, Vishnugupta, that Maurya decided to become personally involved in the political landscape of the day. Vishnugupta was outraged at the Macedonian rule imposed upon his fellow compatriots and was rendered all but hopeless after the defeat of warlord King Porus proved existing Indian armies were unable to match Alexander's forces. With the Macedonian army gone, however, Vishnugupta and his protégé sought to immediately rectify the situation.

Maurya and his mentor traveled first to the Nanda Empire to speak with Dhana Nanda, the ruler whose lands were so vast and whose warriors so plentiful that they'd scared away the Macedonian army with mere rumor alone. When Maurya proposed the creation of an alliance between the kingdoms of India as a means of self-protection, however, Nanda refused– he believed himself powerful and resourceful enough to care for his own lands without conceding anything to a weaker ally. Maurya and Vishnugupta were perplexed and frustrated at Nanda's attitude, but soon, the elder of the two was inspired by a new plan: if Nanda couldn't be persuaded to step up and create a unified India, then perhaps his empire should be stolen by someone who took unity seriously.

Thanks to the tutelage of his patron, Maurya was schooled in the art of warfare. By Vishnugupta's side, Maurya raised an army by creating multiple political alliances with other rulers throughout India. Texts such as